A POSITION PAPER

Conscience and the Law

God's Voice in the Soul, Trained by His Word

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Bottom Line Up Front

Conscience is a real moral judge, but it is not the author of the law. God alone is Lord of the conscience, and Scripture is the standard by which the judge itself must be trained and corrected.

Five things follow:

- A conscience binds only where it agrees with God's Word.
- Disputes of conscience between believers belong to **things indifferent**: matters God has neither commanded nor forbidden.
- To **cause a brother to stumble** is to lead him to sin against his own conscience, not merely to displease him.
- A weak conscience must be **taught, not pressured**. Some things take much discussion and dialogue. And strong and weak owe each other duties.
- The Christian goal is not "follow your conscience." It is a conscience **cleansed by Christ's blood, quieted by the gospel, and trained by Scripture**.

The Governing Kingdom Principle

The King rules the conscience. No one else does.

The Westminster Confession says it plainly:

"God alone is Lord of the conscience, and hath left it free from the doctrines and commandments of men, which are, in any thing, contrary to His

> *Word; or beside it, if matters of faith, or worship. So that, to believe such doctrines, or to obey such commands, out of conscience, is to betray true liberty of conscience: and the requiring of an implicit faith, and an absolute and blind obedience, is to destroy liberty of conscience, and reason also."* (WCF 20.2)

Two truths stand together. The conscience is free from human lordship. But it is not free from God's. It is the King's servant, accountable to His Word.

Notice the second sentence. Believing man-made doctrines "out of conscience" *betrays* liberty. Demanding blind obedience *destroys* it, "and reason also." So the Confession guards the conscience from two directions: from those who would bind it without God's Word, and from the man who would surrender it without thinking.

But liberty is not license. The Confession immediately adds:

> *"They who, upon pretence of Christian liberty, do practice any sin, or cherish any lust, do thereby destroy the end of Christian liberty, which is, that being delivered out of the hands of our enemies, we might serve the Lord without fear, in holiness and righteousness before Him, all the days of our life."* (WCF 20.3)

Every section that follows returns to this principle: **God alone binds the conscience, and He binds it by His Word.**

What Conscience Is

The New Testament word is *syneidēsis*: literally, "co-knowledge," a "knowing with." Conscience is the self knowing itself before a standard. It is the mind's built-in power to pass moral judgment on ourselves. It approves or disapproves our actions, thoughts, and plans. When it condemns, it tells us we deserve to suffer for what we did.

It has two elements:

1. **Moral awareness**: knowing that certain things are right or wrong.
2. **Moral application**: applying those laws to a specific situation.

Paul pictures it as a courtroom inside the soul. Conscience bears witness, while "their conflicting thoughts accuse or even excuse them" (Rom. 2:15). It testifies. It prosecutes. Sometimes it defends.

Conscience judges us by the highest standard we know. So we sometimes call it "God's voice in the soul." In a sense it is, but only in a derived sense. It is a witness, not a lawgiver. Even Paul's clear conscience did not acquit him: "I am not aware of anything against myself, but I am not thereby acquitted. It is the Lord who judges me" (1 Cor. 4:4).

And notice whom conscience judges: *ourselves*. It is not a commission to sit in judgment over a brother's liberty. "Who are you to pass judgment on the servant of another?" (Rom. 14:4).

Conscience Reflects God's Law, but Is Not Infallible

God has written the work of His law on every human heart (Rom. 2:14–15). Experience confirms it. Every culture knows murder, theft, and betrayal are wrong.

But the conscience fell with the rest of man. It is damaged, not destroyed. It still speaks, but it does not always speak truly. Regeneration begins its repair; it does not finish it in a day.

So conscience can be:

- **Misinformed**: sincerely wrong for lack of knowledge (Acts 26:9; John 16:2).
- **Conditioned**: trained to call evil good (Isa. 5:20).
- **Defiled**: corrupted along with the mind (Titus 1:15).
- **Seared**: dulled by repeated sin until it no longer warns (1 Tim. 4:2; Eph. 4:19).

The New Testament gives a fuller diagnosis. Read together, its texts describe a range of conditions:

The conscience in the New Testament

Condition	What it means	Texts
Good / clear	Rightly informed; no unconfessed guilt	Acts 23:1; 24:16; 1 Tim. 1:5, 19
Weak	Condemns what God permits	Rom. 14:1–2; 1 Cor. 8:7–12
Defiled	Corrupted by an unbelieving mind; nothing seems pure	Titus 1:15
Seared	Dulled by repeated sin; no longer warns	1 Tim. 4:2
Evil	Burdened with guilt only Christ can remove	Heb. 10:22

Condition	What it means	Texts
Purified	Cleansed by Christ's blood to serve God	Heb. 9:14

So what follows? A sincere conscience is not thereby a correct one. Paul persecuted the church in good conscience (Acts 23:1; 26:9). Sincerity measures honesty, not accuracy.

Therefore the verdicts of conscience are received as God's voice only when they match God's truth in Scripture. The conscience must be educated to judge scripturally.

Things Indifferent

Before we can speak of a weak conscience, we must define the ground it stands on. Theologians call it *adiaphora*: things indifferent. These are matters Scripture neither commands nor forbids.

In Paul's day they were food, drink, and days. "One person believes he may eat anything, while the weak person eats only vegetables" (Rom. 14:2). "One person esteems one day as better than another, while another esteems all days alike" (Rom. 14:5). Meat offered to idols fell in the same category (1 Cor. 8:4–8).

Why does this matter? Because the weak-conscience problem arises only here. Where God has commanded, there is nothing to negotiate. Where God has forbidden, there is nothing to accommodate. A man who thinks adultery is permissible does not have a "strong" conscience. He has a seared one.

So the first question in any dispute of conscience is not "Who is offended?" It is "Has God spoken?" There are only three answers:

1. **God has commanded it.** Obey, whatever anyone's conscience says (Acts 5:29).
2. **God has forbidden it.** Refuse, whatever anyone's conscience allows.
3. **God has neither commanded nor forbidden it.** Here is liberty, and here love governs how liberty is used (1 Cor. 8:9).

One caution. Things indifferent in themselves are not indifferent in their use. Eating meat is indifferent. Eating it to wound a brother is not (Rom. 14:15). Motive, circumstance, and love can make a lawful act sinful for us.

This is what it means to say: **don't bind (forbid) where God has not bound, and don't loose (permit) where He has.** The line between bound and free is drawn by Scripture alone.

The Weak Conscience

A weak conscience condemns what God permits. Superstition or scruple leads a believer to treat as sin an action Scripture does not forbid. Paul calls this a "weak" conscience (Rom. 14:1–2; 1 Cor. 8:7, 12).

Now here is the hard part. The weak believer is mistaken. Yet if he acts against his conscience, he sins: "whatever does not proceed from faith is sin" (Rom. 14:23).

Why? The sin lies not in the act but in the defiance. He does what he believes God forbids. He tramples what he takes to be the King's voice.

So the weak conscience presents a real dilemma. It must not be left in its error forever. But it must not be overridden by

force. Only one road remains: it must be taught. And the road has two lanes, because both strong and weak carry obligations.

What the strong owe the weak

The strong must not despise the weak (Rom. 14:3). They must not flaunt their liberty before them (Rom. 14:15, 21). They bear with the failings of the weak and do not simply please themselves (Rom. 15:1). And they stand ready to give up a lawful liberty for love: "If food makes my brother stumble, I will never eat meat" (1 Cor. 8:13).

What the weak owe the strong

But the duties run both ways. "Let not the one who abstains pass judgment on the one who eats, for God has welcomed him" (Rom. 14:3). The weak brother may not condemn the strong for using a freedom God has given.

Nor may he stay weak by choice. Weakness is a condition to be outgrown, not a position to be defended (Heb. 5:12–14). He owes his brothers a teachable spirit. And he owes the church the courtesy of not making his scruple its rule.

What It Means to Cause Stumbling

"Stumbling" may be the most misused word in this whole discussion. Many hear it as "offending" or "displeasing." That is not Paul's meaning.

To cause a brother to stumble is to lead him to act against his own conscience, and so to sin. Paul's example is precise. A weak brother sees a strong brother eating in an idol's temple and is "encouraged" to eat too, though his conscience condemns it (1 Cor. 8:10). The word is literally "built up." The strong brother's liberty becomes the weak brother's permission. Then the weak

brother sins, “and so by your knowledge this weak person is destroyed, the brother for whom Christ died” (1 Cor. 8:11).

Romans says the same: “it is wrong for anyone to make another stumble by what he eats” (Rom. 14:20). The harm is not hurt feelings. The harm is a brother led into sin against his own faith (Rom. 14:23).

So what follows? A brother who merely dislikes my liberty has not stumbled. He has disagreed. He is not in danger of sinning against his conscience. He is in danger of judging mine (Rom. 14:3–4).

This answers what is sometimes called the “tyranny of the weaker brother.” If every objection counted as stumbling, the most scrupulous member would become the church’s lawgiver. Paul refuses that. He bent for those who might be led into sin (Acts 16:3). He did not bend for those who demanded conformity as a test of the gospel (Gal. 2:3–5).

Weak brother or legalist?

	The weak brother	The legalist
His conscience	Sincerely troubled	Settled, and imposing itself on others
His posture	“Help me understand.”	“Conform to my rule.”
His danger	Sinning against his own conscience	Judging others; adding to God’s Word
Paul’s response	Accommodate and teach (Acts 16:3; Rom. 14:1)	Refuse and rebuke (Gal. 2:3–5, 11–14)

Taught, Not Pressured

Someone with a weak conscience should never be pressured or cajoled into violating it. Pressure can change behavior. It cannot change conviction. And behavior without conviction is sin (Rom. 14:23).

So persuasion is the only lawful path. This is the "come now, let us reason together" principle (Isa. 1:18). Or, as Gangadeen puts it: "Some things take much discussion and dialogue."

Paul models it. He reasoned with people from the Scriptures (Acts 17:2). He told Timothy the Lord's servant must be "able to teach," correcting opponents "with gentleness" (2 Tim. 2:24–25).

But the principle needs three qualifications.

1. The goal is truth, not mere agreement

Isaiah 1:18 is not a negotiation. It is courtroom language: God states His case so Judah will repent. Dialogue with a weak brother aims at a conscience brought under Scripture, not a compromise between two opinions. Each one is to be "fully convinced in his own mind" (Rom. 14:5), and convinced by the Word.

2. The strong yield liberty while the dialogue continues

Love makes room for the conversation to take time. The strong do not press their freedom on the weak in the meantime (Rom. 14:15, 21; 1 Cor. 8:13). Liberty is real. But love governs its use.

3. The Spirit does the persuading

We open the Scriptures. Only God binds or frees the conscience (WCF 20.2). So we need not rush, and we must not force. The servant teaches; God grants repentance leading to a knowledge of the truth (2 Tim. 2:25).

Conscience and Authority

God alone is Lord of the conscience. But God has also ordained authorities, in the church and in the state. How do they relate? The Confession answers that liberty and lawful authority are not enemies:

> *"And because the powers which God hath ordained, and the liberty which Christ hath purchased, are not intended by God to destroy, but mutually to uphold and preserve one another; they who, upon pretence of Christian liberty, shall oppose any lawful power, or the lawful exercise of it, whether it be civil or ecclesiastical, resist the ordinance of God."* (WCF 20.4)

In the church

Elders have real authority. Church courts may "ministerially" settle controversies of faith and cases of conscience. Their decisions are to be received with reverence and submission, "if consonant to the Word of God" (WCF 31.2). But the Confession is honest about their limits:

> *"All synods or councils, since the apostles' times, whether general or particular, may err; and many have erred. Therefore they are not to be*

made the rule of faith, or practice; but to be used as a help in both." (WCF 31.3)

So the church may teach the conscience, counsel it, and discipline open sin. But it may not invent new sins or new duties. Its authority is ministerial, not legislative. It serves the King's Word. It does not add to it.

In the civil sphere

The same principle runs through both kingdoms. Christians submit to the magistrate "not only to avoid God's wrath but also for the sake of conscience" (Rom. 13:5). Ordinary obedience to lawful government is itself a matter of conscience before God.

But when the state commands what God forbids, or forbids what God commands, the answer is Peter's: "We must obey God rather than men" (Acts 5:29). Conscience submits to every lawful authority *because* it first submits to the King.

The governing principle holds in both spheres: **no human authority binds the conscience beyond the Word of God.**

Objections Answered

"Isn't this relativism? Everyone just follows his own conscience."

No. Relativism makes conscience the standard. We make Scripture the standard. Patience with the weak does not concede his conscience is right. It refuses to make him sin while he learns.

"Won't endless accommodation let the weak rule the church?"

A fair concern, and Paul draws the line. He circumcised Timothy for the sake of those who might stumble (Acts 16:3). But

he refused to circumcise Titus when false teachers made it a test of the gospel (Gal. 2:3–5). A weak brother is still learning. A legalist is binding others. Bearing with the first is love; yielding to the second is surrender (WCF 20.2 cuts both ways).

> **Acts 16:3** — "Paul wanted Timothy to accompany him, and he took him and circumcised him because of the Jews who were in those places, for they all knew that his father was a Greek."
>
> **Galatians 2:3–5** — "But even Titus, who was with me, was not forced to be circumcised, though he was a Greek. Yet because of false brothers secretly brought in—who slipped in to spy out our freedom that we have in Christ Jesus, so that they might bring us into slavery—to them we did not yield in submission even for a moment, so that the truth of the gospel might be preserved for you."
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> **Westminster Confession of Faith 20.2** — "God alone is Lord of the conscience, and hath left it free from the doctrines and commandments of men, which are, in any thing, contrary to His Word; or beside it, if matters of faith, or worship. So that, to believe such doctrines, or to obey such commands, out of conscience, is to betray true liberty of conscience: and the requiring of an implicit faith, and an absolute and blind obedience, is to destroy liberty of conscience, and reason also."

"If conscience can be wrong, why not ignore it?"

Because acting against conscience is sin (Rom. 14:23), and repeated violation sears it (1 Tim. 4:2). The cure for a

misinformed conscience is information, not defiance. Correct the instrument. Don't smash it.

> **Romans 14:23** — "But whoever has doubts is condemned if he eats, because the eating is not from faith. For whatever does not proceed from faith is sin."

> **1 Timothy 4:1–2** — "Now the Spirit expressly says that in later times some will depart from the faith by devoting themselves to deceiving spirits and teachings of demons, through the insincerity of liars whose consciences are seared."

"Who decides what is indifferent?"

Scripture does. Not by a list of every possible act, but by what it sets down expressly and what follows from it "by good and necessary consequence" (WCF 1.6). The church helps by teaching, and its confessions summarize what it has learned. But no court and no individual may add to the Word. Where a believer is still unsure, he waits until he is convinced (Rom. 14:5), and keeps studying.

> **Westminster Confession of Faith 1.6** — "The whole counsel of God concerning all things necessary for His own glory, man's salvation, faith and life, is either expressly set down in Scripture, or by good and necessary consequence may be deduced from Scripture: unto which nothing at any time is to be added, whether by new revelations of the Spirit, or traditions of men. Nevertheless, we acknowledge the inward illumination of the Spirit of God to be necessary for the saving understanding of such things as are revealed in the Word: and that there are some

> circumstances concerning the worship of God, and government of the Church, common to human actions and societies, which are to be ordered by the light of nature, and Christian prudence, according to the general rules of the Word, which are always to be observed."
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> **Romans 14:5** — "One person esteems one day as better than another, while another esteems all days alike. Each one should be fully convinced in his own mind."

"Doesn't 'much discussion' mean we never reach a conclusion?"

No. Dialogue is the road, not the destination. Scripture is clear enough to settle the matter. The patience is for the person, not for the truth.

The Christian Goal: A Cleansed and Trained Conscience

The Christian goal is not merely to "follow your conscience." It is a conscience free from guilt and able to guide us in a holy direction (Acts 24:16; 1 Tim. 1:5).

Cleansed by the blood

Conscience has one great problem: it accuses truly. When it says "guilty," it is usually right. And no amount of resolve can silence a true accusation. Only a sufficient answer can.

That answer is Christ. His blood purifies our conscience "from dead works to serve the living God" (Heb. 9:14). We draw near "with our hearts sprinkled clean from an evil conscience" (Heb. 10:22). Justification removes condemnation (Rom. 8:1).

Law and gospel

Here the Reformed distinction between law and gospel is vital. The law *trains* the conscience: it tells us what is right. The gospel *quiets* the conscience: it tells us what Christ has done. Confuse the two and you get either a seared conscience (law without weight) or a tormented one (law without gospel).

John gives the pastoral word: "whenever our heart condemns us, God is greater than our heart, and he knows everything" (1 John 3:20). The believer's final court is not his conscience. It is God, who has justified him in Christ.

The scrupulous conscience

Some believers carry a different burden. Their conscience is not seared but over-sensitive. It accuses where God does not. Every choice becomes a possible sin. Every confession feels insufficient.

This, too, needs teaching, not pressure. The scrupulous believer must learn three things: what God actually requires, which is the law rightly read; what Christ has actually done, which is the gospel fully believed; and that the *feeling* of guilt is not the same as guilt. Luther knew this battle well. His remedy was not to look inward harder, but to look outward to Christ.

Trained by the Word

Once freed and protected, the conscience grows. Scripture, the means of grace, and the ordinary course of Christian life train our "powers of discernment" to "distinguish good from evil" (Heb. 5:14). Luther stood at Worms on exactly this ground: "My conscience is captive to the Word of God." Free from men. Captive to the King.

Application for Church Life and Discipleship

- **Ask first: has God spoken?** Command, prohibition, or liberty. Settle that before anything else.
- **Teach before you correct.** Ask what Scripture says before asking what the person should do.
- **Don't bind (forbid) where God has not bound.** And don't loose (permit) where He has.
- **Distinguish stumbling from disagreeing.** Yield to the brother who might be led into sin. Teach the one who merely objects.
- **Give the weak time.** Some things take much discussion and dialogue. Plan for more than one conversation.
- **Limit your liberty for love.** In shared settings, the strong defer (Rom. 14:21).
- **If you are the weaker brother, stay teachable.** Don't judge the strong, and don't make your scruple the church's rule (Rom. 14:3).
- **Leaders: teach the conscience; don't legislate it.** Church authority is ministerial (WCF 31.3).
- **Guard your own conscience.** Keep it clean through repentance; don't sear it by habit (1 Tim. 1:19).
- **Point the accusing conscience to Christ,** not to more effort (1 John 3:20).
- **Pray for the Spirit's work.** Persuasion is His.

Conclusion

Conscience is a moral judge, not the author of the law. Scripture is the standard by which the judge itself must be trained and corrected. We do not make conscience sovereign; we bring it under the authority of God's Word.

And where a brother's conscience is weak, we reason with him. Patiently. From the Scriptures. In love. Until the King's Word has its way.

Soli Deo Gloria

Sources: ESV Study Bible, Theological Notes, "Conscience and the Law." Westminster Confession of Faith 1.6; 20.2–4; 31.2–3 (American edition). Scripture quotations are from the ESV.